



Ministry Of Information, Communication
Technology, Postal And Courier Services

ZIMBABWE NATIONAL CHILD ONLINE PROTECTION POLICY

2026-2030



unicef 
for every child

Ministry Of Information, Communication
Technology, Postal And Courier Services

ZIMBABWE NATIONAL CHILD ONLINE PROTECTION POLICY

2026-2030





FOREWORD

The rapid advancement of information and communication technologies (ICTs) has fundamentally transformed how society learns, works and interacts. For Zimbabwe, digital technologies present immense opportunities for inclusive development, innovation, education and economic growth. However, these same technologies also introduce new and evolving risks, particularly for children, who are increasingly engaging with digital platforms from a very young age.

Children today navigate a digital environment that offers unprecedented access to knowledge and connection, yet exposes them to serious threats such as cyberbullying, online grooming, sexual exploitation and abuse, exposure to harmful content, and the misuse of personal data. These risks, if left unaddressed, undermine children's rights, safety, dignity, and overall well-being. It is therefore both a constitutional obligation and a moral imperative for the Government of Zimbabwe to ensure that children are adequately protected in the digital space, while still enabling them to fully benefit from the opportunities of the digital age.

The National Child Online Protection Policy (2026–2030) represents a decisive and coordinated national response to these emerging challenges. Anchored in the Constitution of Zimbabwe, the Children's Act [Chapter 5:06], and aligned with our regional and international commitments, including the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child and its General Comment No. 25, this policy provides a comprehensive, rights-based framework for safeguarding children in the digital environment.

This policy recognises that child online protection is a shared responsibility. Government, the private sector, educators, parents and guardians, civil society, communities, and children themselves all play vital roles. It therefore promotes a multi-sectoral and collaborative approach, emphasising prevention, protection, response, accountability, and the empowerment of children through digital literacy and resilience. Central to the Policy is the principle that digital products and services must be safe for children by design and by default, and the child's best interests must guide all decisions and actions.

The development of this policy has been informed by extensive consultations with stakeholders nationwide, including children and young people, whose voices and lived experiences have been instrumental in shaping a framework that is both practical and responsive to the Zimbabwean context. I commend all Ministries, Departments, and Agencies, Development Partners, Civil Society Organisations, industry players, academics, and community representatives, who contributed their expertise and commitment to this important national endeavour.

As we implement this policy, I call on all stakeholders to translate its provisions into concrete actions that make a measurable difference in children's lives. Together, we can build a digital ecosystem that is safe, inclusive, and empowering; one in which every child in Zimbabwe is protected from harm and enabled to realise their full potential, both online and offline.

Hon. Tatenda A. Mavetera, M.P.

Minister of ICT, Postal and Courier Services

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

The Government of Zimbabwe acknowledges the contributions of all institutions, organisations, and individuals who participated in the development of this National Child Online Protection Policy. Appreciation is extended to the following partners, whose insights and expertise informed the policy:

- the Zimbabwe Child Online Protection Committee (ZICOP)
- UNICEF
- Government Ministries, Departments, and Agencies
- Regulatory Authorities
- Law Enforcement and Justice Institutions
- Civil Society Organisations
- Academia
- Development Partners
- Private sector stakeholders and
- community representatives.

Special recognition is accorded to children and young people, who shared their experiences and perspectives during consultations. Their contributions ensured that the policy reflects realities of children’s lives in the digital environment. The Government of Zimbabwe further acknowledges the technical guidance drawn from international frameworks and partners, including the United Nations system, the WeProtect Global Alliance, and regional bodies, which strengthened the policy’s alignment with global best practice.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Zimbabwe has made significant strides in expanding access to information and communication technologies, resulting in widespread connectivity and increased participation in the digital economy. National internet penetration now exceeds 80 per cent, with mobile technologies serving as the primary gateway to online access for most citizens. While this digital transformation presents substantial opportunities for education, innovation and social inclusion, it has also introduced new and complex risks for children. As children increasingly engage with digital platforms for learning, communication, and recreation, they are exposed to online threats such as cyberbullying, online grooming, sexual exploitation and abuse, exposure to harmful or age-inappropriate content, and the misuse of personal data.

The National Child Online Protection Policy has been developed in response to these emerging challenges. It provides Zimbabwe with a single, coherent, and coordinated national framework for the prevention of, and response to, online risks and harms affecting children. The policy is grounded in Zimbabwe’s Constitution and the Children’s Act [Chapter 5:06] and aligns with Zimbabwe’s regional and international obligations, including the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child and its General Comment No. 25 on children’s rights in the digital environment.

The policy’s overarching purpose is to ensure that the rights of every child in Zimbabwe are respected, protected, and fulfilled in the digital environment. It seeks to protect children from all forms of online violence, exploitation, and abuse while simultaneously promoting children’s participation, empowerment, and digital resilience.

To achieve these aims, the policy is structured around nine interrelated policy action areas. These include strengthening institutional capacity and coordination; enhancing the legal and regulatory framework; improving prevention, response, and support mechanisms; promoting technical controls and corporate responsibility; integrating child online protection into education systems; expanding public awareness and communication initiatives; strengthening research and evidence generation; advancing global and regional cooperation and leadership; and establishing robust monitoring, evaluation, and learning systems.

Ultimately, the National Child Online Protection Policy envisions a digital ecosystem in which digital products and services are safer for children by default, risks are proactively mitigated, and reliable data and evidence inform policy decisions.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Foreword	ii	5. Education	29
Acknowledgements	ii	Objective	29
Executive summary	iv	Strategic Policy Actions	29
Table of contents	v	6. Public Awareness And Communication	30
Preface	vi	Objective	30
Acronyms	vii	Strategic Policy Actions	30
Definitions	viii	7. Research And Development	30
Terms and concepts	ix	Objective	30
		Strategic Policy Actions	31
		9. Monitoring, Evaluation, And Learning	31
		Objective	31
		Strategic Policy Actions	31
Section i	1	Section iv	33
Background And Context	1	Implementation Framework	33
Introduction	1	Governance Matters	33
		Partnerships And Collaboration	33
		Implementation Milestones	33
Section ii	8	Section v	35
Guiding Principles And Cross-Cutting Themes	8	Conclusion	35
Child Online Protection Guiding	8		
Legislative Framework	8		
Cross-Cutting Themes	23	Section vi	36
		Appendices	36
		Appendix A – International Law, Convention	
		On The Rights Of The Child	36
		Appendix B – Inspire: Seven Strategies	
		For Ending Violence Against Children	40
		Appendix C – Model National Response	41
		Appendix D – List Of Existing Legislation	
		Relevant To Child Online Protection	
		In Zimbabwe	42
		Appendix E – Zimbabwe Child	
		Online Protection Committee	42
Section iii	25		
Policy Action Areas	25		
1. Institutional Capacity	25		
Objective	25		
Strategic Policy Actions	25		
2. Legal And Regulatory Framework	25		
Objective	25		
Strategic Policy Actions	25		
3. Prevention, Response, And Support Mechanisms	27		
Objective	27		
Strategic Policy Actions	27		
4. Technical Control And Corporate Responsibility	28		
Objective	28		
Strategic Policy Actions	28		

PREFACE

The National Child Online Protection Policy (2026–2030) has been developed to recognise the profound and irreversible ways in which digital technologies are shaping children’s lives in Zimbabwe. As access to the internet, mobile devices, and digital platforms continues to expand, children are increasingly engaging in the digital environment for learning, social interaction, creative expression, and recreation. While these developments offer significant opportunities for empowerment and inclusion, they also expose children to new and evolving risks that require deliberate, coordinated, and sustained policy responses.

This policy provides Zimbabwe with a dedicated, comprehensive national framework for preventing and responding to online risks and harms affecting children. It brings together existing laws, policies, strategies, and institutional arrangements into a coherent approach that strengthens coordination, clarifies roles and responsibilities, and promotes accountability across all sectors. In doing so, it seeks to ensure that children’s rights are respected, protected, and fulfilled in the digital environment, in accordance with the Constitution of Zimbabwe, the Children’s Act [Chapter 5:06], and Zimbabwe’s regional and international obligations.

The development of the policy was informed by extensive desk reviews, stakeholder consultations, and engagement with children and young people across diverse settings. Input was received from government ministries, departments, and agencies; regulatory authorities; law enforcement and justice institutions; civil society organisations; academia; development partners; the private sector; and community representatives. Importantly, the perspectives and lived experiences of children were central to the policy development process, ensuring the policy reflects the realities of children’s digital lives and the evolving online risks and opportunities they encounter in Zimbabwe.

Grounded in the principles of the best interests of the child, non-discrimination, inclusion, participation, and shared responsibility, this policy adopts a child-rights-based, evidence-informed approach. It recognises that in addition to regulation, child online protection requires a balanced combination of prevention, education, technical safeguards, responsive support services, and the empowerment of children, parents, guardians, and educators. The policy further promotes the principles of safety-by-design and safety-by-default, calling on digital service providers to embed child safety into the design and operation of digital products and services.

The National Child Online Protection Policy is intended to be a practical, living framework that guides action for 2026–2030. Its successful implementation depends on sustained political commitment, adequate resourcing, effective partnerships, and continuous monitoring, evaluation, and learning. Through the policy, Zimbabwe affirms its commitment to building a safe, inclusive, and enabling digital environment, one in which every child is protected from harm, and supported to realise their full potential in the digital age.

ACRONYMS

APC	Association for Progressive Communication
CDC	Centers for Disease Control
COP	Child Online Protection
CRC	Convention on the Rights of the Child
CSAM	Child Sexual Abuse Material
CSE	Child Sexual Exploitation
DHS	Demographic Health Survey
DSD	Department of Social Development (within MoPSLSW)
GoZ	Government of Zimbabwe
GBV	Gender-Based Violence
GSMA	Global System for Mobile Communication Association
ICMEC	International Centre for Missing and Exploited Children
ICT	Information and Communication Technology
IoT	Internet of Things
ISP	Internet Service Providers
IWF	Internet Watch Foundation
MICS	Multiple Indicator Cluster Survey
MICTPCS	Ministry of Information Communication Technology, Postal and Courier Services
MoJLPA	Ministry of Justice, Legal and Parliamentary Affairs
MoPSE	Ministry of Primary and Secondary Education
MoPSLSW	Ministry of Public Service, Labour and Social Welfare
NAP	National Action Plan for Children)
NCMS	National Case Management System
NGO	Non-Governmental Organization
POTRAZ	Postal and Telecommunication Regulatory Authority of Zimbabwe
SRSG	Special Representative of the UN Secretary-General
UNICEF	United Nations Children's Fund
VAC	Violence Against Children
ZICOP	Zimbabwe Child Online Protection Committee
ZRP	Zimbabwe Republic Police

DEFINITIONS

For this policy, the following definitions shall apply:

- Child:** shall mean any person under 18 years of age, as prescribed by the law.
- Child Rights:** shall mean the complete range of basic human rights accorded to children by the Constitution of Zimbabwe, the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child, the African Charter on the Rights and Welfare of the Child and other applicable human rights treaties.
- Child Online Protection:** means the range of preventive, response, and support services and systems required to keep children safe online.
- Cyberbullying:** shall mean the willful and repeated harm inflicted through the use of computers, cell phones, and other information and technology devices.
- Cyberspace:** means an environment in which communication over computer or other ICT networks occurs.
- Guardian or Caregiver:** shall mean any person with a responsibility to provide parental care to a child by law or custom.
- Internet:** means a global wide-area network that connects digital devices worldwide.
- Online Risks:** shall mean any aspect of the digital experience that may result in, or increase the likelihood of harm occurring to the child.
- Harms:** shall mean any actual injury resulting from encountering a risk, resulting in physical, sexual, or psychological injury to the child.
- Vulnerable Child:** means any person below the age of 18 who has been or is likely to be in a risky situation where he or she is likely to suffer significant physical, emotional, or mental stress.

TERMS AND CONCEPTS

Child Sexual Abuse:

Child Sexual Abuse is defined as any sexual activity with a child who according to the national law of Zimbabwe has not yet reached the legal age of consent for sexual activities. It is important to note that Child Sexual Abuse may be contact abuse, or "non-contact" abuse, including sexual harassment of children and verbal harassment such as unwanted sexual comments, or causing a child to witness sexual activities or sexual abuse or coercing, forcing or threatening a child into sexual activities with a third party – an act which gains particular relevance within the digital environment.

Child Sexual Exploitation

Child Sexual Exploitation is defined as the solicitation or intentional causing of a child to witness or engage in sexual activities for money or any other consideration. This includes child prostitution, child pornography and the sale of children. Child Sexual Exploitation is distinguished from child sexual abuse on the basis of the underlying notion of exchange of sexual activity present in exploitation and which is generally absent in concepts of abuse and violence.

Child sexual abuse materials (CSAM)

Child Sexual Abuse Material is defined in the Cyber and Data Protection Act as any representation through publication, exhibition, cinematography, electronic means or any other means whatsoever, of a child, a person made to appear as a child or realistic material representing a child, engaged in real or simulated explicit sexual activity, or any representation of the sexual parts of a child for primarily sexual purposes. In Zimbabwe, any individual who knowingly uses technology or otherwise through digital means produces, offers or makes available, distributes or transmits, procures or obtains (for oneself or for another), possesses and/or entices a child into the production or distribution of CSAM is guilty of an offence as detailed in the Cyber and Data Protection Act.

Grooming of children for sexual purposes

Grooming of children refers to the process of establishing a relationship with a child either in person or through the use of ICT to facilitate online or offline sexual contact. The CRC Guidelines regarding the implementation of the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the sale of children, child prostitution and child pornography notes that "although grooming or the solicitation of children for sexual purposes is not covered explicitly in the Optional Protocol, it is a form of child sexual exploitation that may constitute an offence covered by the Optional Protocol."

Online harassment

Online harassment generally encompasses any range of actions or unwanted contact that is used to create a hostile, threatening, intimidating or frightening environment for the victim. This may take place on any online platform or through the use of any digital or connected device. Online Sexual Harassment refers to any unwanted sexual conduct, attention or action, either repeated or singularly, that occurs in the digital space. Online sexual harassment may exist in isolation of offline harassment, or may be strongly correlated to, or lead to, offline sexual harassment or other forms of sexual or other violence.

Sexual Extortion of children (including 'Sextortion')

Sexual extortion of children (often referred to as 'sextortion'), refers to the blackmailing of a person with the help of self-generated images, video or any other sexual content that may be viewed as compromising, in order to extort sexual favours, financial returns, or any other benefit from that person, usually accompanied by the threat of sharing or making public the self-generated content.

Cyber-Bullying

While international instruments do not provide any concise definition of cyber-bullying, it is most commonly taken to refer to the willful and repeated harm inflicted through the use of computers, cell phones, and other electronic devices. The Government of Zimbabwe considers cyber-bullying to occur when a person unlawfully and intentionally by means of information and communication technologies generates and sends any data message to another person, or posts on any material whatsoever on any electronic medium accessible by any person, with the intent to coerce, intimidate, harass, threaten, bully or cause substantial emotional distress, or to degrade, humiliate or demean the person of another or to encourage a person to harm himself or herself.

Phishing

Phishing refers to fraudulent attempts to obtain access to an individual's personal or private information, data, or files, through pretending to be a trustworthy individual, service provider or other institution, using electronic means. Most commonly associated with the theft of financial data such as banking account numbers, passwords or credit card details, it may also be used to elicit passwords of other accounts such as email or cloud-based services.





SECTION I – BACKGROUND AND CONTEXT

INTRODUCTION

The rapid spread of technology and digital tools has transformed global economies and societies, reaching even the most remote communities and households. The acceleration has resulted in children and young people inevitably using online platforms for school, play, and communication. However, inequalities and disparities in children's access to technology and increase in digital skills and capacity have been exacerbated by the COVID-19 pandemic.

As the potential benefits and opportunities of a "connected" society extend to households and individuals, so do the risks of abuse and violent behaviour in the digital environment. According to the Association for Progressive Communication (APC) and Human Rights Watch, "The Internet and mobile technologies provide new ways to connect, share resources and experiences, and build communities. However, these digital spaces have also provided tools and platforms for the replication and continuation of the perpetration of violence."

Of particular importance to children is that access to the internet is increasingly recognised as a fundamental right, both in itself and as a means to realise other fundamental rights, including the rights to education and information. According to the World Wide Web Foundation (WWF), "the internet is a public good and should be used, managed and governed as such... For children, the internet is a means, a tool, a cross-cutting mechanism to the realisation of all other rights."

The Committee on the Rights of the Child emphasises recognition of the internet as a mechanism to realise other rights, noting that "the rights of every child must be respected, protected and fulfilled in the digital environment." Innovations in digital technologies affect children's lives and their rights in ways that are wide-ranging and interdependent, even in the absence of internet access. Meaningful access to digital technologies can support children to realise their full range of civil, political, cultural, economic, and social rights.

If the internet offers a gateway to the realisation of many rights for children, the importance of the internet and digital environment for children with disabilities, as well as other often marginalised children cannot be overstated. According to the Committee on the Rights of the Child, "The digital environment opens new avenues for children with disabilities to engage in social relationships with peers, access information and participate in public decision-making processes."

This framing serves as the starting point for the Zimbabwe National Child Online Protection Policy. While online protection of children is incrementally incorporated into Zimbabwe's legislative and policy framework, there is no dedicated policy to guide an evidence-based, integrated approach to keeping children safe online across all relevant sectors. This policy therefore sets out a coherent framework to ensure that all children in Zimbabwe are safe online, and free to realise the essential benefits and opportunities the digital space offers and to fully exercise their rights, online and offline.

THE ZIMBABWE CONTEXT

The latest available data indicates that approximately 81.38% of the population has access to the internet, with mobile technologies accounting for the vast majority of connectivity and a penetration rate of 102.64%. Included in these statistics are children who are increasingly becoming present online. The statistics reveal a global crisis where over 300 million children are victims of online sexual abuse and exploitation each year. In Zimbabwe, the 2011 National Baseline Survey on Life Experiences of Adolescents and the report on Addressing Social Norms that Underpin Violence Against Children, reveal concerning statistics. This critical gap persists in recent comprehensive, and representative data on online violence, abuse, and exploitation. Available evidence points to growing vulnerabilities along the lines of gender, age, and disability, compounded by persistently low levels of digital literacy that materially increase the risk of online harms. It is within this context of rapid digital expansion that violence against children must not be underestimated.

When considering the rights of children in Zimbabwe in the digital age and the potential risks and harms they may face, it is important to include children who do not yet have access to the internet or digital devices. As noted in General Comment No. 25 of the CRC, the rights of children in the digital environment apply to all children, including those who do not yet have access, as they are also affected by these technologies and the internet, despite not having access to them. Many children consulted in the development of this policy noted that they did not have access to the internet or had very limited access, and yet their lives were still impacted by the technology itself, as well as the way in which the technology and the internet were used by those around them, including their friends and peers.

Recognising the pivotal role of the digital space in children's lives and well-being, and in response to the emergence of specific forms of online violence, the Government of Zimbabwe embarked on several concurrent processes, being:

- i. The setting up of the Zimbabwe Child Online Protection Committee (ZICOP), a multi-sectoral stakeholder committee comprising key government ministries, industry, and civil society.
- ii. Commencing a process of updating and reforming legislation, including:
 - The enactment of the Cyber and Data Protection Act in 2022
 - The review of the Criminal Law (Codification and Reform) Act in 2024
 - The National Plan of Action for Children comprising a Pillar on ending violence against children in all its forms.
 - Updating guidelines and training materials to incorporate all forms of online violence against women and children, accompanied by training for police, social workers, and the judiciary.
 - The planned review and update of the National Case Management for the Welfare and Protection of Children framework – to incorporate issues on online protection, previously not articulated in current tools.
 - The planned development of a National Harmonised Parenting Manual



These initiatives, along with several progressive efforts to raise awareness among children, parents, and other stakeholders about online safety and practical steps to stay safe online, represent significant progress toward a safer online environment. This represents an important departure point for this policy. However, with the absence of national or indeed any reliable data on the extent and nature of online violence against exploitation of children, these have tended to fill an ad hoc space in the national landscape.

A review of regional practice in efforts to curb online violence against children underscores the need for Zimbabwe to adopt a dedicated legal framework addressing children’s access to social media. Countries that have introduced relevant measures include Kenya’s Data Protection Act 2019, South Africa’s Protection of Personal Information Act (POPIA) 2013, and Nigeria’s Data Protection Act 2023.

Globally, Australia enacted the Online Safety Amendment (social media Minimum Age) Act in 2024, establishing a minimum age of 16 for social media access, while the United Kingdom’s Online Safety Act (2023) places a statutory duty of care on platforms to protect children. These two jurisdictions currently represent the most advanced and enforceable legislative models internationally and serve as the primary benchmarks for Zimbabwe to take concrete steps to legislate parameters that govern social media access for children.

Currently, violence against children (in all its forms) as a concept is being coordinated through the coordinative platform of the National Case Management System for the Welfare and Protection of Children in Zimbabwe. This policy seeks, among other things, to ensure that this common evidence-driven approach is adopted, as there is limited evidence of such a coordination platform for online violence.





VISION

A safe, inclusive, and empowering digital environment in which all children in Zimbabwe are protected from online harm and fully realise their rights, their potential, and fully exploit opportunities in the digital age.



MISSION

To provide a coordinated, rights-based, multi-sectoral national framework to prevent and respond to online risks and harms affecting children in Zimbabwe while promoting child participation, digital resilience, accountability, and the responsible development and use of digital technologies by all stakeholders.



GOAL

The overarching goal of the National Child Online Protection Policy is a holistically safe and progressive digital environment, advancing the rights, safety, and well-being of all children in Zimbabwe through effective prevention, protection, response, and accountability mechanisms

The Ministry of Information Communication Technology, Postal and Courier Services will lead the coordination, development, review and implementation of the Zimbabwe Child Online Protection Policy and related legislative frameworks, ensuring that this Policy to protect children is prioritised at high-level.

Specifically, the Zimbabwe Child Online Protection Policy seeks to achieve the following objectives:

- a. To establish a single, coherent national framework for child online protection in Zimbabwe that guides the coordinated actions of all stakeholders.
- b. To provide clear guiding principles for all laws, policies, strategies, and decisions relating to the digital environment.
- c. To ensure that all decisions, policies, programmes, and interventions are fully aligned with the Constitution of Zimbabwe and the Children's Act [Chapter 5:06].
- d. To protect children in Zimbabwe from all forms of online violence, exploitation, and abuse.
- e. To promote practical, context-appropriate measures that mitigate online risks and minimise harm to children.
- f. To promote children's rights, participation, and digital resilience in Zimbabwe.
- g. To strengthen institutional coordination, leadership, and accountability for child online protection across all sectors.
- h. To embed safety-by-design and safety-by-default principles across Zimbabwe's digital ecosystem.
- i. To promote accountability for children's safety across all sectors of Zimbabwean society.



Several regional initiatives, policies, and treaties also inform the development of this policy, addressing the welfare and protection of children in general and, more specifically, the welfare and protection of the African child in the digital environment. These include:

- i. 1990 African Charter on the Rights and Welfare of the Child
- ii. 1989 United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child
- iii. 2002 UN CRC Optional Protocol on the sale of children, child prostitution and child pornography
- iv. 2006 United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities and Sustainable Development Goals
- v. 2014 African Union Convention on Cyber Security and Personal Data Protection
- vi. 2024 Bogota Call to Action
- vii. 2024 UN Convention on Cybercrime

In addition, the Government of Zimbabwe notes that through this policy, obligations and guidelines are set out in international instruments, including:

- i. The INSPIRE Strategies
- ii. The WeProtect Model National Response
- iii. ITU/UNICEF Child Online Protection Guidelines

This National Child Online Protection Policy thus builds on these initiatives and provides an integrated protection framework that links and weaves together international and regional initiatives and obligations, legislation, strategies, and plans into a coherent prevention and response framework.

GUIDING STRATEGIES

In addition to the UNCRC, the Government of Zimbabwe is also guided by several international frameworks for addressing violence against children and keeping children safe online. The INSPIRE framework, developed and endorsed by the World Health Organisation, UNICEF, CDC, UNODC, UNGEI, and other international bodies, provides seven evidence-based strategies for preventing violence against children. As a Pathfinder country, Zimbabwe is guided by the INSPIRE strategies in the review of its National Plan of Action for Orphans and Vulnerable Children, the development of the Country Pledge to End Violence Against Children, and the development of the National Roadmap to End Violence Against Children. Each of the seven INSPIRE strategies directly contributes to child online protection. The application of the INSPIRE strategies to the digital environment includes:

The implementation and enforcement of laws

These include laws that; criminalise the production, possession, distribution, or viewing of child sexual abuse material (while not criminalising children or victims of self-generated sexual content); criminalise sexual abuse and exploitation of all kinds; and that hold industry responsible and accountable for acting on all reports or publishing of such material on their platforms.

Norms and values

Changing adherence to harmful gender and social norms that; promote gender inequality and vulnerability; promote peer and bystander interventions and support when witnessing any form of online violence; and implementing community mobilisation programmes to enhance online safety.

Safe environments

More conventionally applicable to preventing violence outside of the digital space, safe environments can be applied to the creation of safe online spaces and environments through active peer involvement, the designing of platforms, digital products and technology in a way that factors in child users in their design (safety by design) and that defaults to the safety and wellbeing of child users (safety by default), and that are designed in a way that minimises the collection of data and personal information from children.

Parent and caregiver support

In the case of the prevention of violence outside of the digital space, evidence points to the efficacy of home visits, programmes delivered in community settings, and comprehensive parenting programmes. In the online setting, support for parents and guardians is delivered through the same mechanisms and, where possible, integrated into existing evidence-based or promising practice programmes to cover all aspects of parenting and caregiving. Additionally, parents and guardians, including elderly guardians, can access digital literacy programming.

Strengthening the economy and income

While there are as yet, no evaluated programmes to assess the impact of income and economic strengthening on online violence outcomes, several risk factors related to economic and income stressors have been strongly associated with online violence, including poor socio-economic status and income inequality. Investing in income and household strengthening through cash transfer and group savings and loans, combined with gender equality, has been shown to have significant positive outcomes in reducing violence against children.

Response and support services

Counselling and therapeutic services for child victims of online violence, screening for risk and trauma combined with interventions, as well as juvenile offender interventions, can all yield positive outcomes for online violence. Therapeutic and counselling services are effective for both direct victimisation and secondary victimisation or exposure to online violence.

Education and life skills

Enhancing children's awareness and knowledge of sexual violence and abuse and how to protect themselves from it; life and social skills training, including communication and conflict management skills; adolescent intimate partner violence prevention programmes that integrate online sexual violence, such as image-based sexual abuse ("revenge porn"), matters around consent and equitable gender relations.





SECTION II

GUIDING PRINCIPLES AND CROSS-CUTTING THEMES

CHILD ONLINE PROTECTION GUIDING LEGISLATIVE FRAMEWORK

International, Regional, and National Regulations

The rights of all children are paramount and underpin policies, legislation, and practices at the global, regional, and national levels. Children's rights are globally enshrined in the International Bill of Rights, including the Universal Declaration on Human Rights 1948, the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights 1966 (ratified by Zimbabwe in 1991) and the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights 1966 (ratified by Zimbabwe in 1991), as well as the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (ratified by Zimbabwe in 1990), together with its Optional Protocols on the Sale of Children, Child Prostitution and Child Pornography (ratified by Zimbabwe in 2012), and Children in Armed Conflict (ratified by Zimbabwe in 2013), the African Charter on the Rights and Welfare of the Child, the Convention on Cybercrime and the African Union Convention on Cyber Security and Personal Data Protection.

While the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child is not fully domesticated by an Act of Parliament in Zimbabwe, Zimbabwean law broadly aligns with the CRC and cites it in legal judgements, addressing other matters relating to children.

The CRC gives four guiding principles for the protection of children's rights:

- The right to non-discrimination (art. 2)
- The best interests of the child (art. 3, para. 1)
- The right to life, survival, and development (art. 6)
- The right to be heard (art. 12)

These principles are indivisible and equally relevant. One principle cannot apply at the expense of the other. This is particularly important when considering how children's rights apply online, where the safety and well-being of children must be ensured while promoting the benefits and opportunities available to them. All measures taken to protect children online must not come at the expense of any other indivisible and equal rights, such as the right to access information, to education, or to privacy.

WeProtect Global Alliance's mission is clearly articulated as: "to protect children from the growing threat of online sexual exploitation and abuse... believ(ing) every child deserves a safe digital world, safeguarded by proactive measures and collective global action. By uniting over 300 governments,



the private sector, civil society, and international organisations, develop(ing) policies and collaborative solutions and driv(ing) real-world change, achieving together what no single organisation can accomplish alone."

The rights of children in Zimbabwe are enshrined within the Constitution of Zimbabwe and within the Children's Act [Chapter 5:06]. Section 81 of the Zimbabwean Constitution codifies the best interest of the child and the right of the child to protection from economic and sexual exploitation. The Rights of Children, aligned with the Convention on the Rights of the Child, are also mentioned in several other pieces of legislation, including:

- **The Children's Act [Chapter 5:06]**
- **The Criminal Law (Codification and Reform) Act [Chapter 9:07]**
- **The Criminal Procedure and Evidence Act 1927**
- **The Guardianship of Minors Act 1961**
- **The Refugees Act 1978 (amended 2001)**
- **The Labour Relations Act 1985**
- **The Education Act 1987 (amended 2020)**
- **The Marriages Act [Chapter 5:17] (2022)**
- **The Citizenship of Zimbabwe Act 1984**
- **The Births and Deaths Registration Act 1986**

The legislation obliges all persons in positions of responsibility for, or assuming the burden of care for children as equally responsible for ensuring online and technological safety. Equally important is ensuring the realisation of rights alongside the ensuing responsibilities. The onus rest with all tasked with the position of care for children, including parents and guardians, teachers, community leaders, among others.

The implementation of the National Child Online Protection Policy shall be guided by the following interrelated principles and values:

1. Best Interests of the Child

The best interests of the child shall be a primary consideration in all actions, decisions, laws, policies, programmes, and services relating to the digital environment.

2. Child Rights-Based Approach

All interventions under this policy shall be grounded in a child rights-based approach that respects, protects, and fulfils the full range of children's rights in the digital environment.

3. Non-Discrimination and Inclusion

All children in Zimbabwe, regardless of gender, disability, socio-economic status, geographic location, family circumstance, or access to technology, shall be entitled to equal protection and support.

4. Child Participation and Agency

Children shall be recognised as rights holders and active participants in matters affecting their engagement with digital technologies.

5. Shared Responsibility and Accountability

Child online protection is a shared responsibility among government, industry, service providers, educators, parents, guardians, communities, and children.

6. Safety by Design and Safety by Default

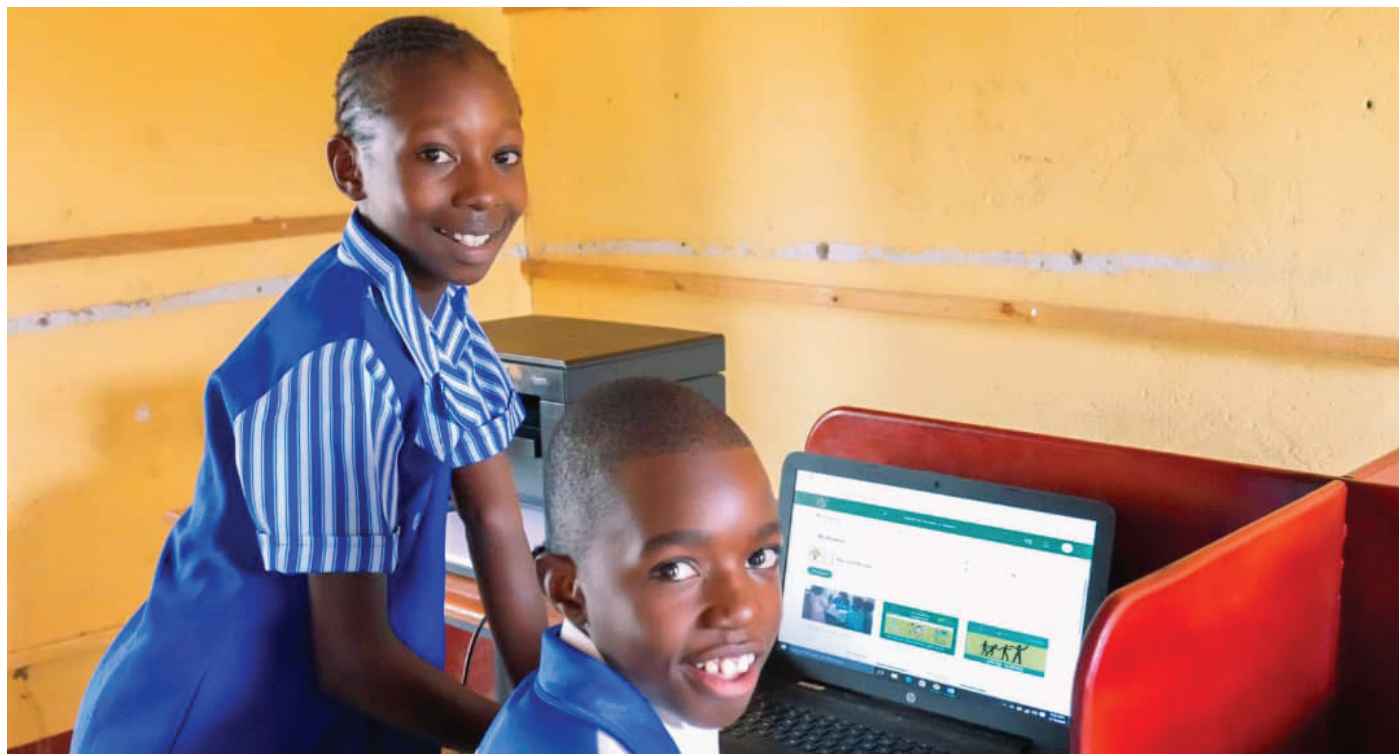
The policy adopts the principles of safety-by-design and safety-by-default, requiring that digital technologies are designed with child safety embedded from the outset.

7. Evidence-Based and Adaptive Approach

Policy decisions and interventions shall be informed by the best available national, regional, and international evidence, data, and research.

8. Cultural Sensitivity and Community Engagement

The implementation of this policy shall respect Zimbabwe's positive cultural values, traditions, and social structures.



CROSS-CUTTING THEMES

Risk and Harms

The policy recognises that online risks exist across a spectrum and may result in varying degrees of harm to children. Risks include exposure to harmful content, contact with malicious actors, conduct that places children in vulnerable positions, contract/consumer which may result in misuse of personal data and cross-cutting risks – affecting children's privacy, mental health and well-being. The Policy distinguishes between risks (potential for harm) and harms (actual injury or negative outcomes experienced by children). Not all exposure to risk results in harm, and children's experiences vary based on age, gender, developmental stage, resilience, and context. The policy adopts a balanced approach that seeks to reduce serious harms while avoiding excessive restrictions that would limit children's rights and opportunities in the digital environment.

Resilience

Building digital resilience among children, parents, guardians, and educators is a central objective of this policy. Digital resilience refers to the knowledge, skills, confidence, and support networks that enable children to navigate online environments safely, make informed decisions, recover from negative experiences, and seize opportunities. Resilience is not solely an individual responsibility; it is strengthened by supportive relationships, quality education, accessible resources, and enabling environments. The policy promotes resilience-building alongside protection measures, recognising that children need both safeguarding and empowerment.

Chain of Responsibility

All actors in the digital ecosystem bear responsibility for child safety. This includes technology companies, internet service providers, media, content creators, government agencies, educators, parents, guardians and children themselves. The policy adopts the principle that those who design, provide, regulate, and facilitate digital services have a duty of care toward child users. This chain of responsibility recognises that:

- Technology companies must design safe products and respond to harmful and illegal content.
- The government must provide effective laws, policies, and enforcement
- Educators must equip children with digital literacy and critical thinking skills
- Parents and guardians must provide guidance, supervision, and support appropriate to children's age and capacity
- Communities must create supportive offline environments that reinforce online safety
- Children themselves have a role in responsible digital citizenship, supported by adults

The policy emphasises that the primary duty of protection rests with adults and institutions, not with children.

Safety by Design and by Default

Digital products and services must be designed with child safety as a foundational principle, not

as an afterthought. Safety-by-design means that child protection considerations are integrated throughout the entire development process of digital technologies, from conception to deployment. Safety-by-default means that the safest settings and highest privacy protections are automatically applied to child users, without requiring them or their parents to navigate complex settings. The policy calls on all technology providers serving Zimbabwean children to adopt these principles, including:

- Age-appropriate design that accounts for children's developmental stages
- Privacy-protective default settings
- Proactive measures to prevent exposure to harmful and illegal content
- Transparent and accessible reporting mechanisms
- Regular safety audits and impact assessments
- Meaningful consultation with children in design processes

Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

Continuous monitoring, evaluation, and learning are essential to ensure the policy remains responsive to emerging technologies and evolving risks. The policy establishes mechanisms for:

- Regular data collection on children's online experiences, risks, and harms
- Evaluation of intervention effectiveness
- Adaptation of strategies based on evidence
- Sharing of lessons learned among stakeholders
- Transparency in reporting progress and challenges
- Child participation in monitoring and evaluation processes

Monitoring and evaluation will be conducted in accordance with the National Monitoring and Evaluation Policy Framework and will prioritise ethical research practices, particularly in research involving children.



SECTION III - POLICY ACTION AREAS

1. INSTITUTIONAL CAPACITY

Objective

To establish an accountable and effective institutional framework that promotes and facilitates the safety and protection of children online.

Strategic Policy Actions

- a) **Establish an Inter-Ministerial COP Committee:** An Inter-Ministerial Child Online Protection Committee comprising senior representatives from relevant Ministries and Departments shall be established to guide policy development and ensure the mainstreaming of COP across Government.
- b) **Operationalise the Zimbabwe Child Online Protection Committee (ZICOP):** ZICOP shall function as the national multi-stakeholder coordination platform to support implementation, strengthen inter-agency cooperation, and provide technical advice on child online protection matters.
- c) **Adopt Harmonised Definitions and Standards:** All stakeholders shall adopt standardised terminology and definitions consistent with international best practice to enhance coordination, investigations, prosecutions, and international cooperation.
- d) **Develop an Implementation and Accountability Framework:** A national implementation plan shall be developed outlining roles and responsibilities, resource requirements, performance indicators, and monitoring and reporting mechanisms.

2. LEGAL AND REGULATORY FRAMEWORK

Objective

To establish a coherent, harmonised, and enforceable legal and regulatory framework that safeguards children online while enabling safe digital participation.

Strategic Policy Actions

- a) **Strengthen and Harmonise Domestic Legislation:** The government shall review and strengthen all substantive and procedural laws relating to child online protection to ensure consistency across the child protection and criminal justice systems.

- b) Align with Regional and International Frameworks:** Domestic legislation shall be aligned with applicable regional and international instruments, including the Convention on the Rights of the Child, the Optional Protocol on the Sale of Children, Child Prostitution and Child Pornography, ILO Convention No. 182, SADC Model Law on Cybercrime, and the African Union Convention on Cyber Security and Personal Data Protection and the UN Convention on Cybercrime.
- c) Mainstream Child Online Protection Across All Relevant Laws and Policies:** Child Online Protection provisions shall be integrated into all relevant legislation, policies, and regulatory instruments, including the Children's Act [Chapter 5:06], the Cyber and Data Protection Act 2021, the Criminal Law Code of 2024, gender-based violence-related laws and issues, ICT regulatory frameworks, broadband strategies, and the National Action Plan for Children.
- d) Ensure Safe and Equitable Digital Access:** Broadband policies and industry initiatives shall promote safe, inclusive, and equitable access to the internet for all children, including children with disabilities and other marginalised groups, with accessible content and assistive technologies.
- e) Establish Age-Appropriate Digital and Data Governance Standards:** The government shall develop model age-appropriate guidelines for online services and children's data governance, consistent with international best practice.
- f) Strengthen Enforcement and Accountability:** Laws relating to online child abuse and exploitation shall be effectively enforced, with harmonised sentencing guidelines recognising such offences as aggravating factors.
- g) Protect and Support Child Victims and Child Offenders:** Legislation shall provide child-friendly reporting and redress mechanisms, prevent the criminalisation of child victims, and promote appropriate diversion and rehabilitation measures for child offenders.
- h) Strengthen Child Data Protection Safeguards:** Robust, age-appropriate data protection measures shall apply to all public and private entities processing children's data.
- i) Mandate Child Rights Impact Assessments:** Child rights impact assessments shall be required in the development, deployment, and regulation of digital technologies and services.
- j) Regulate Online Service Providers:** Legislation shall empower competent authorities to require Internet Service Providers and digital platforms to detect, remove, and act on Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM) and provide for enforcement measures in cases of non-compliance.
- k) Enhance Capacity and International Cooperation:** The government shall strengthen the capacity of law enforcement, prosecutors, the judiciary, and child protection actors and enhance cooperation with regional and international bodies, including INTERPOL, to address cross-border online offences.
- l) Legal and Institutional Framework:** The Government of Zimbabwe shall strengthen the legal and institutional framework addressing online violence by explicitly providing for cross-border violations, jurisdictional cooperation, and mutual legal assistance in cases involving digital harms.
- m) The Government of Zimbabwe shall develop and enact a specific legal and policy framework to prevent, criminalise, and respond to the online radicalisation of children and young people.**

3. PREVENTION, RESPONSE, AND SUPPORT MECHANISMS

Objective

To establish integrated, accessible, and child-friendly prevention, response, and support systems for child online protection across Zimbabwe.

Strategic Policy Actions

- a) **Integrate Child Online Safety into Parenting and Community Education:** Child online safety shall be incorporated into national parenting programmes and community-based prevention initiatives to strengthen early intervention and family support mechanisms.
- b) **Implement a National Awareness and Communication Strategy:** Government shall develop and implement sustained public awareness campaigns to prevent online child abuse and promote responsible digital behaviour among children, parents, educators, and communities.
- c) **Provide Child-Friendly Psychosocial Support Services:** Accessible and quality psychosocial support services shall be made available to child victims/survivors and witnesses of online abuse and exploitation.
- d) **Integrate COP into Existing Child Protection Systems:** Child Online Protection shall be fully integrated into national child protection and child rights systems, including the National Case Management System for the Welfare and Protection of Children in Zimbabwe and the National Action Plan for Children, to avoid parallel structures and ensure coordinated service delivery.
- e) **Strengthen Data Collection and Reporting Mechanisms:** Child protection reporting systems, including helplines and case management platforms, shall collect disaggregated data on online abuse and exploitation to inform evidence-based interventions.
- f) **Promote Digital Literacy and Resilience:** Evidence-based digital literacy programmes shall be implemented for children, parents, and caregivers to strengthen digital resilience, risk awareness, and safe online participation, with inclusive provisions for children with disabilities.
- g) **Institutionalise COP within Schools and Community Structures:** Child Online Protection shall be integrated into national, provincial, district, and school child protection committees, with designated COP focal persons in schools and communities.
- h) **Support Peer-Based and Life Skills Programmes:** Peer-to-peer initiatives, bystander interventions, and life skills programmes shall be implemented to strengthen children's socio-emotional competencies and reporting pathways.
- i) **Integrate COP into School-Based Life Skills and Health Education:** Child Online Protection shall be incorporated into age-appropriate life skills and sexual and reproductive health education programmes to address online risks linked to harmful gender norms and digital exploitation.
- j) **Strengthen One-Stop Centres and Case Handling Procedures:** All One-Stop Centres dealing with children across government and other recognised stakeholder establishments shall be capacitated to manage cases of online child abuse and exploitation, including procedures for reporting, case management, and lawful content removal, with adherence to referral pathway stakeholders.

- k) **Strengthen CSAM Reporting Mechanisms:** The national Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM) reporting mechanisms, including the hotline portal established in partnership with the Internet Watch Foundation, shall be strengthened, widely publicised, and made accessible to all children, including children with disabilities.
- l) **Establish Clear Take-Down and Content Removal Procedures:** Clear processes shall be established for issuing and enforcing take-down notices for CSAM and other illegal content, including accountability mechanisms and child-friendly reporting channels.
- m) The Government of Zimbabwe shall expressly criminalise the production, possession, distribution, transmission, procurement, or sharing of AI-generated child sexual abuse material (CSAM), including deepfake imagery, synthetic video, digitally manipulated content, and fully algorithmically generated material that depicts a minor in sexual conduct or in a sexualised manner.

4. TECHNICAL CONTROL AND CORPORATE RESPONSIBILITY

Objective

To establish minimum industry standards that embed the best interests of the child into the design, development, and delivery of digital products and services.

Strategic Policy Actions

- a) **Embed the Best Interests of the Child in Product Design:** Industry stakeholders shall demonstrate that the best interests of the child are incorporated into the design, development, and deployment of all products and services that may be accessed by children.
- b) **Adopt Age-Appropriate Design Standards:** Industry shall develop and implement age-appropriate design standards for online services, guided by international best practice, including the General Comment No. 25 on children's rights in relation to the digital environment, and addressing Contact, Conduct, Content and Contract risks.
- c) **Implement Safety-by-Design and Privacy-by-Design:** All digital products and services likely to be accessed by children shall incorporate safety-by-design and privacy-by-design principles, including secure and private default settings.
- d) **Strengthen Accessible Reporting and Safety Controls:** Platforms and digital services shall integrate child-friendly reporting mechanisms, clear safety settings, and transparent terms appropriate to children's age and evolving capacities.
- e) **Ensure Industry Accountability for Children's Data Protection:** Responsibility for safeguarding children's data shall rest primarily with industry actors, with clear accountability, compliance, and redress mechanisms in cases of failure.
- f) **Establish Age-Rating and Classification Mechanisms:** Appropriate age-rating and classification systems for digital applications, and devices shall be developed and enforced to protect children from harmful or inappropriate material.

- g) Strengthen Institutional Safeguards in Child-Focused Environments:** Schools, libraries and other institutions serving children shall implement appropriate content filtering, monitoring and digital safety measures consistent with national and international standards.
- h) Enhance Technical Cooperation to Combat CSAM:** The industry shall cooperate with national law enforcement and international partners to detect, flag, and remove Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM), including the use of internationally recognised image-hashing technologies, in collaboration with bodies such as INTERPOL.
- i)** The Government of Zimbabwe shall introduce a mandatory AI Child Safety Impact Assessment (CSIA) requirement for digital service providers deploying artificial intelligence systems that are accessible to children within Zimbabwe.
- j)** All digital products and services operating in Zimbabwe that use AI-driven content recommendation or ranking systems and are accessible to children shall be required to implement child-specific algorithmic safeguards.

5. EDUCATION

Objective

To ensure that all children in Zimbabwe acquire the digital skills, competencies, and values necessary to stay safe online and to benefit from digital opportunities through formal and informal education systems.

Strategic Policy Actions

- a) Integrate Digital Literacy into School Curricula:** Digital literacy, including digital citizenship and online safety, shall be incorporated into primary and secondary school curricula, with inclusive provisions for children with disabilities and diverse learning needs.
- b) Strengthen Teacher Training on Child Online Protection:** Child Online Protection (COP) and digital safety shall be integrated into pre-service teacher training, and extended to school counsellors and social workers to strengthen early identification, response, and referral of online abuse cases.
- c) Provide Accredited In-Service COP Training:** In-service COP training shall be provided to educators and accredited for professional development and career advancement.
- d) Integrate COP into Early Childhood Development (ECD) Programmes:** Online safety and age-appropriate technology use shall be incorporated into Early Childhood Development programmes and parenting education initiatives.
- e) Expand Non-Formal Digital Literacy Programmes:** Digital literacy and COP programmes shall be delivered to out-of-school youth through non-formal education platforms, in partnership with civil society and community-based organisations.
- f) Implement Targeted Outreach for Rural and Underserved Communities:** Targeted digital literacy and online safety initiatives shall be rolled out in rural, peri-urban, and underserved communities to ensure universal access to essential online safety skills.

- g) **Promote Critical Thinking and Media Literacy:** Education programmes shall integrate critical thinking, media literacy, and the identification of misinformation as core components of online safety curricula for children, parents, and educators.
- h) **Address Gender Norms and Online Violence through Education:** School-based programmes promoting gender equality shall incorporate child online protection content to address online sexual exploitation, image-based abuse, and other forms of gender-based digital violence.

6. PUBLIC AWARENESS AND COMMUNICATION

Objective

To promote consistent, evidence-based, and inclusive public awareness of child online protection and online safety across Zimbabwe.

Strategic Policy Actions

- a) **Develop Core National Messaging on Child Online Protection:** Government shall develop a standardised set of evidence-based Child Online Protection (COP) messages to ensure consistent communication across Ministries, agencies, and stakeholders, informed by consultations including children.
- b) **Tailor Messaging for Diverse Audiences:** Targeted awareness materials shall be developed for children (across different age groups), parents and caregivers, educators, child protection practitioners, and the general public, with inclusive adaptations for vulnerable and marginalised groups, including children with disabilities.
- c) **Link Awareness to Reporting and Support Mechanisms:** All public awareness messaging shall include clear information on reporting channels, referral pathways, and available remedies.
- d) **Ensure Accessibility and Multilingual Communication:** COP information shall be disseminated across government platforms and made available, at a minimum, in English, Shona, and Ndebele, and in accessible formats.
- e) **Leverage Multi-Channel Communication Platforms:** Government, in partnership with industry and civil society, shall utilise radio, print, social media, and edutainment platforms to deliver COP messaging at national and community levels.
- f) **Promote a Balanced Child Rights Approach:** Public awareness initiatives shall promote a balanced approach to children's rights in the digital environment, reinforcing protection alongside children's rights to education, information, and privacy, consistent with the General Comment No. 25 on children's rights in relation to the digital environment.

7. RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT

Objective

To establish a national data, research, and innovation framework to inform evidence-based Child Online Protection (COP) policy and practice in Zimbabwe.

Strategic Policy Actions

- a) **Promote Evidence-Based Research and Innovation:** Government shall promote the use of national child population data and research to inform the design, development, and evaluation of digital products, services, and COP interventions, embedding safety-by-design and privacy-by-design principles.
- b) **Develop a COP Research Ethics Framework:** A national research ethics framework shall be established to guide all research relating to Child Online Protection, ensuring the best interests of the child, ethical data collection, and responsible processing of children's data.
- c) **Establish a Regulatory Data and Monitoring Framework:** A structured framework shall be developed to enable the ethical collection and analysis of COP-related data for monitoring and evaluation purposes, including clearly defined provisions for regulatory access to relevant industry data where demonstrably in the best interests of the child.

8. GLOBAL COOPERATION AND LEADERSHIP

Objective

To strengthen effective, transparent, and strategic collaboration on Child Online Protection (COP) at regional and international levels, and to promote Zimbabwe's leadership in advancing best practice.

Strategic Policy Actions

- a) **Strengthen Regional and International Engagement:** Government shall actively engage regional and international partners to address the transnational nature of online child abuse and exploitation, promote knowledge exchange, and advance a coordinated regional COP agenda.
- b) **Formalise Bilateral and Multilateral Cooperation:** Government shall establish and strengthen bilateral and multilateral agreements with relevant law enforcement, regulatory, education, and cybersecurity partners, including organisations such as INTERPOL and the Internet Watch Foundation.
- c) **Promote Regional Research and Leadership in COP:** Zimbabwe shall contribute to the development of a regional evidence base on Child Online Protection through research, innovation, and knowledge-sharing initiatives, positioning the country as a regional leader in COP policy and practice.

9. MONITORING, EVALUATION, AND LEARNING

Objective

To establish a robust evidence and learning framework to monitor progress, evaluate impact, and strengthen Child Online Protection (COP) outcomes in Zimbabwe.

Strategic Policy Actions

- a) Establish a National COP Baseline:** Government shall conduct a nationally representative baseline study on child online protection, covering digital access, use, risks, harms, opportunities, and access to services, including vulnerable and marginalised populations.
- b) Conduct Regular National Surveys:** Periodic nationally representative surveys shall be carried out to capture children's experiences and perspectives, inform research and development, and support monitoring and evaluation of COP initiatives.
- c) Integrate Monitoring in Public Awareness Initiatives:** All COP awareness and communication programmes shall include mechanisms to assess reach, knowledge uptake, and behaviour change among target audiences.
- d) Secure Funding for Evaluations and Impact Assessments:** Government shall partner with industry and other stakeholders to fund methodologically sound evaluations of COP interventions for children, parents, caregivers, and other populations to identify effective and promising practices in Zimbabwe.
- e) Translate Research into Child-Friendly and Accessible Formats:** Research findings shall be shared in accessible formats, including child-friendly versions, to facilitate engagement, validation, and feedback from children and youth.
- f) Create a Central Repository of COP Research and Best Practices:** A national, online repository shall be established to host research studies, findings, advocacy materials, training resources, and other relevant information to promote evidence-based COP practice and knowledge sharing within Zimbabwe.



SECTION IV

IMPLEMENTATION FRAMEWORK

GOVERNANCE MATTERS

The implementation of this policy shall be overseen through a multi-tiered governance structure:

- Strategic Oversight: Inter-Ministerial Child Online Protection Committee
- Technical Coordination: Zimbabwe Child Online Protection Committee (ZICOP)
- Operational Implementation: Line Ministries, departments, agencies, and partners
- Sub-national Structures: Provincial and district-level implementation

PARTNERSHIPS AND COLLABORATION

Effective implementation requires sustained collaboration among:

- Government Ministries, Departments, and Agencies
- Law enforcement and Justice institutions
- Regulatory Authorities
- Civil Society Organisations
- Academia and Research institutions
- Development Partners
- Private sector and Digital Service Providers

IMPLEMENTATION MILESTONES

Short-term (Year 1)

- Establish governance structures
- Develop implementation tools
- Initiate awareness activities

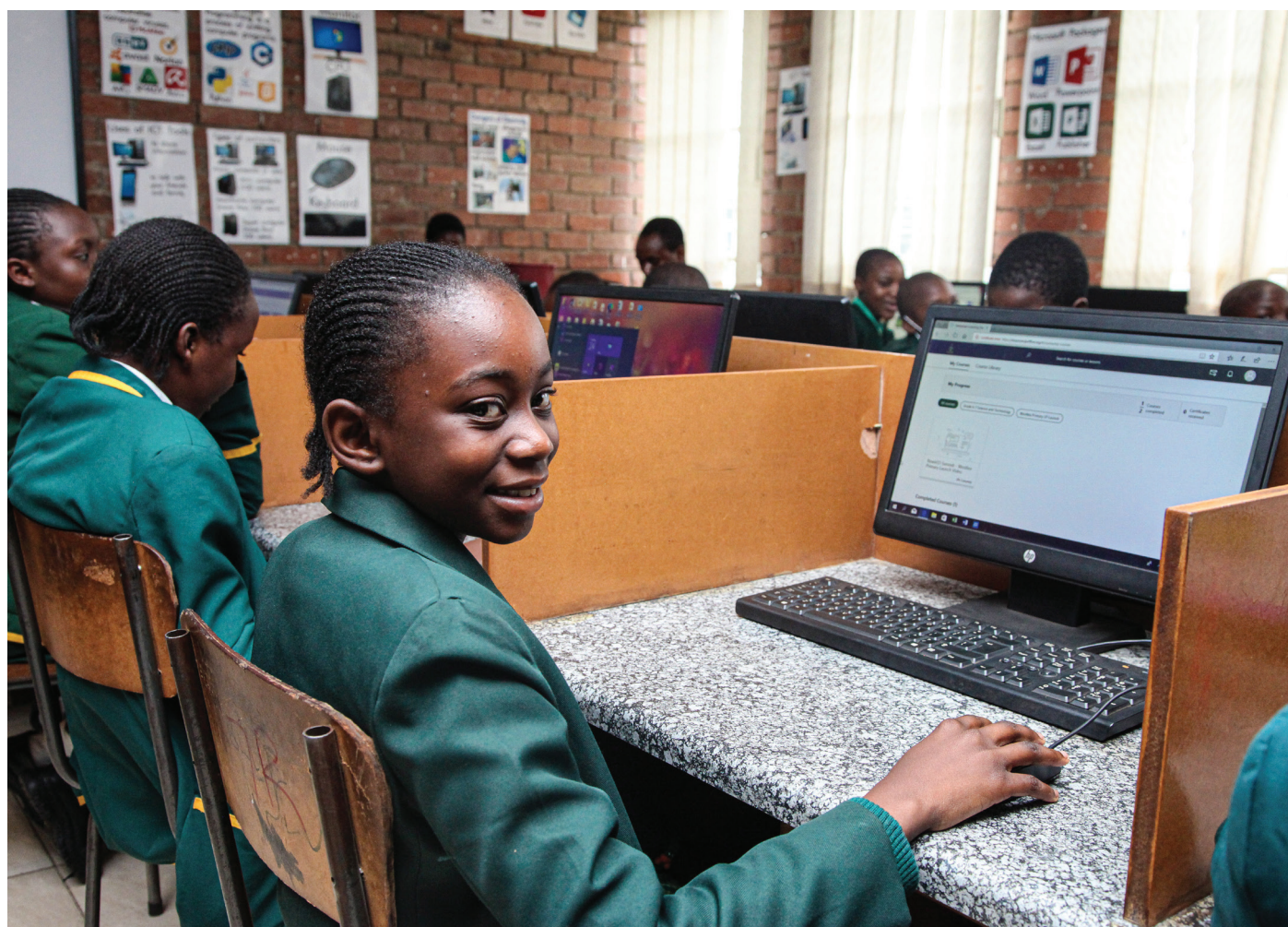
- Integrate into existing child protection systems

Medium-term (Years 2-3)

- Strengthen legal and institutional capacity
- Expand education and prevention initiatives
- Operationalise reporting and response mechanisms
- Improve data collection

Long-term (Years 4-5)

- Consolidate systems
- Scale successful interventions
- Strengthen sustainability
- Adapt to emerging technologies and risks





SECTION V

CONCLUSION

The rapid expansion of digital technologies in Zimbabwe presents both transformative opportunities and complex risks for children. This National Child Online Protection Policy provides Zimbabwe with a comprehensive framework to address these challenges, grounded in the Constitution, aligned with national development priorities, and informed by regional and international best practices.

Through this policy, Zimbabwe seeks to foster a digital environment that is not only safer for children but also inclusive and empowering, one that enables children to develop digital resilience, exercise their rights, and meaningfully benefit from the opportunities of the digital age.

The Government of Zimbabwe calls upon all stakeholders to play their respective roles in translating this policy into tangible outcomes that improve the safety, well-being, and prospects of children across the country.



SECTION VI

APPENDICES

Appendix A – International Law, Convention on the Rights of the Child

The Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC) was adopted by the United Nations General Assembly on 20 November 1989. The CRC recognises children as rights holders and is the primary international instrument that provides the full range of human rights protections to children, as well as regulates the obligation of countries to adapt national laws to ensure, protect, and defend each of the governing principles. The guiding principle of the best interests of the child is one of the most important principles framed within the instrument, which is stated in Article 3:

1. *In all actions concerning children, whether undertaken by public or private social welfare institutions, courts of law, administrative authorities, or legislative bodies, the best interests of the child shall be a primary consideration.*
2. *States Parties undertake to ensure the child such protection and care as is necessary for his or her well-being, taking into account the rights and duties of his or her parents, legal guardians, or other individuals legally responsible for him or her, and, to this end, shall take all appropriate legislative and administrative measures.*
3. *States Parties shall ensure that the institutions, services, and facilities responsible for the care or protection of children shall conform to the standards established by competent authorities, particularly in the areas of safety, health, and the number and suitability of their staff, as well as competent supervision.*

In relation to the sexual abuse and exploitation of children, including through the use of information and communications technologies, Article 34 requires:

States Parties undertake to protect the child from all forms of sexual exploitation and sexual abuse. For these purposes, States Parties shall in particular take all appropriate national, bilateral and multilateral measures to prevent:

- (a) The inducement or coercion of a child to engage in any unlawful sexual activity;*
- (b) The exploitative use of children in prostitution or other unlawful sexual practices;*
- (c) The exploitative use of children in pornographic performances and materials.*

Article 35 stipulates that States Parties shall take all appropriate national, bilateral, and multilateral measures to prevent the abduction of and the sale or traffic in children for any purpose or in any form.

- **Article 39** stipulates that states must take appropriate measures to promote physical and psychological recovery and social reintegration of a child victim of any form of neglect, exploitation, or abuse; torture or any other form of cruel, inhuman, or degrading treatment or punishment; or armed conflicts.



Optional Protocol on the Sale of Children, Child Prostitution and Child Pornography

While the Convention on the Rights of the Child aims to ensure a broad range of human rights for children (including civil, political, economic, social, and cultural rights), there are several articles within the CRC and the Optional Protocol that protect children from all forms of sexual abuse and sexual exploitation.

The Optional Protocol to the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child on the sale of children, child prostitution and child pornography (Optional Protocol or OPSC) entered into force on 18 January 2002. The Optional Protocol contains the following specific provisions relating to child sexual abuse material (child pornography):

- **Article 2 (c)** defines "child pornography" as "any representation, by whatever means, of a child engaged in real or simulated explicit sexual activities or any representation of the sexual parts of a child for primarily sexual purposes."
- **Article 3 (1)** requires States Parties to criminalise child pornography, whether committed domestically or transnationally, on an individual or organised basis.
- **Article 3 (1) (c)** requires States Parties to criminalise simple possession regardless of the intent to distribute.
- **Article 3 (4)** addresses the liability of legal persons and encourages each State Party to establish such liability for offences specific to child pornography. This article reflects the notion that a comprehensive approach requires industry involvement.
- **Article 7** recognises the right of victims to seek compensation.
- **Article 8** requires States Parties to adopt appropriate measures to protect the rights and interests of child victims at all stages of the criminal justice process, with the best interest of the child being the primary consideration.
- **Article 9** requires States Parties to adopt or strengthen, implement, and disseminate laws, administrative measures, social policies, and programmes to prevent the offences that are referred to in the Optional Protocol, paying attention, in particular, to the protection of children who are especially vulnerable to such practices. In addition, Article 9 acknowledges the right of recovery and reintegration of child victims.

The Optional Protocol also encourages the strengthening of international cooperation and assistance and the adoption of extra-territorial legislation. Article 10 (1) addresses the need for international cooperation. As mentioned above, child pornography is readily distributed across borders; without international cooperation, many offenders may evade detection and punishment.

Convention Concerning the Prohibition and Immediate Action for the Elimination of the Worst Forms of Child Labour

The ILO Convention Concerning the Prohibition and Immediate Action for the Elimination of the Worst Forms of Child Labour entered into force on 19 November 2000. The fundamental objective of the Convention is for Members to adopt instruments for the prohibition and elimination of the worst forms of child labour, focusing on national and international actions, and recognizing child pornography as

a form of commercial sexual exploitation.

Within its framework, the following is set forth:

- **Article 3** states that the term “the worst forms of child labour” includes:
 - (a) *all forms of slavery or practices similar to slavery, such as the sale and trafficking of children, debt bondage and serfdom, and forced or compulsory labour, including forced or compulsory recruitment of children for use in armed conflict;*
 - (b) *the use, procuring, or offering of a child for prostitution, for the production of pornography, or for pornographic performances;*
 - (c) *the use, procuring, or offering of a child for illicit activities, in particular for the production and trafficking of drugs as defined in the relevant international treaties;*
 - (d) *work which, by its nature or the circumstances in which it is carried out, is likely to harm the health, safety, or morals of children.*

Council of Europe Convention on the Protection of Children against Sexual Exploitation and Sexual Abuse

The Council of Europe Convention on the Protection of Children against Sexual Exploitation and Sexual Abuse (Lanzarote Convention) focuses on ensuring the best interests of children through prevention of sexual abuse and exploitation, protection and assistance for victims, punishment of perpetrators, and promotion of national and international law enforcement cooperation. The Lanzarote Convention was opened for signature on 25 October 2007, and entered into force on 1 July 2010. The Lanzarote Convention is open for signature by member States, non-member States that have participated in the Convention’s elaboration by the European Union, and for accession by other non-member States. Currently, 41 member States have ratified the Lanzarote Convention, and 6 other member states have signed but not ratified. About offences related to child sexual abuse material (child pornography):

- **Articles 4 to 8** establish preventive measures to be adopted by countries that ratify the Convention to protect children from all forms of sexual exploitation and sexual abuse. This includes the recruitment, training, and awareness-raising of persons who work directly with children; education for children; the creation of preventive intervention programmes or measures and risk assessments; and the promotion of awareness-raising campaigns for the general public.
- **Articles 11 to 14** discuss protective measures and assistance to victims. These include taking the necessary legislative or other measures to: ensure child-serving professionals are not hindered by confidentiality rules from reporting suspected sexual exploitation or sexual abuse of a child; encourage and support the creation of information services such as Internet helplines to provide advice to callers; and assist victims in the short- and long-term in both their physical and psycho-social recovery.
- **Article 20 (1)** requires each party to criminalise producing child pornography; offering or making available child pornography; distributing or transmitting child pornography; procuring child pornography for oneself or for another person; possessing child pornography; and knowingly obtaining access, through information and communication technologies, to child pornography.
- **Article 20 (2)** defines “child pornography” as “any material that visually depicts a child engaged in

real or simulated sexually explicit conduct or any depiction of a child's sexual organs for primarily sexual purposes."

- **Article 21 (1) and (2)** recommend that each party adopt legislation criminalising the activities of those who recruit or coerce a child into participating in child pornography or to knowingly attend pornographic performances involving the participation of children.
- 1. *Each party shall take the necessary legislative or other measures to ensure that the following intentional conduct is criminalised: a. recruiting a child into participating in pornographic performances or causing a child to participate in such performances; b. coercing a child into participating in pornographic performances or profiting from or otherwise exploiting a child for such purposes; c. knowingly attending pornographic performances involving the participation of children.*
- 2. *Each Party may reserve the right to limit the application of paragraph 1.c to cases where children have been recruited or coerced in conformity with paragraph 1. a or b.*

Article 22 establishes the obligation of countries to criminalise the corruption of minors for sexual purposes.

"Each Party shall take the necessary legislative or other measures to criminalise the intentional causing, for sexual purposes, of a child who has not reached the age set in application of Article 18, paragraph 2, to witness sexual abuse or sexual activities, even without having to participate."

- **Article 23** defines the solicitation of children for sexual purposes (grooming) and requires each party to take necessary measures to criminalise the conduct.

"Each Party shall take the necessary legislative or other measures to criminalise the intentional proposal, through information and communication technologies, of an adult to meet a child who has not reached the age set in application of Article 18, paragraph 2, for the purpose of committing any of the offences established in accordance with Article 18, paragraph 1. a, or Article 20, paragraph 1. a, against him or her, where this proposal has been followed by material acts leading to such a meeting."

- **Article 24** addresses attempted crimes as well as aiding and abetting.
- **Article 26** addresses the issue of corporate liability.
- 1. *Each party shall take the necessary legislative or other measures to ensure that a legal person can be held liable for an offence established in accordance with this convention, committed for its benefit by any natural person, acting either individually or as part of an organ of the legal person, who has a leading position within the legal person, based on: a. power of representation of the legal person; b. an authority to take decisions on behalf of the legal person; c. an authority to exercise control within the legal person.*
- 2. *Apart from the cases already provided for in paragraph 1, each party shall take the necessary legislative or other measures to ensure that a legal person can be held liable where the lack of supervision or control by a natural person referred to in paragraph 1 has made possible the commission of an offence established in accordance with this Convention for the benefit of that legal person by a natural person acting under its authority.*

3. *Subject to the legal principles of the Party, the liability of a legal person may be criminal, civil, or administrative.*
4. *Such liability shall be without prejudice to the criminal liability of the natural persons who have committed the offence.*

Article 28 addresses the aggravating circumstances that should be considered in the determination of sentences for the commission of certain crimes, including the existence of serious injury, the use of serious violence or torture, and the perpetrator being a family member, among others.

Appendix B – INSPIRE: Seven Strategies for Ending Violence Against Children

Strategy	Approach	Sectors	Cross-cutting activities
 Implementation and enforcement of laws	• Laws banning violent punishment of children by parents, teachers or other caregivers • Laws criminalizing sexual abuse and exploitation of children • Laws that prevent alcohol misuse • Laws limiting youth access to firearms and other weapons	Justice	Multisectoral actions and coordination
 Norms and values	• Changing adherence to restrictive and harmful gender and social norms • Community mobilization programmes • Bystander interventions	Health, Education, Social Welfare	
 Safe environments	• Reducing violence by addressing “hotspots” • Interrupting the spread of violence • Improving the built environment	Interior, Planning	
 Parent and caregiver support	• Delivered through home visits • Delivered in groups in community settings • Delivered through comprehensive programmes	Social Welfare, Health	
 Income and economic strengthening	• Cash transfers • Group saving and loans combined with gender equity training • Microfinance combined with gender norm training	Finance, Labour	Monitoring and evaluation
 Response and support services	• Counselling and therapeutic approaches • Screening combined with interventions • Treatment programmes for juvenile offenders in the criminal justice system • Foster care interventions involving social welfare services	Health, Justice, Social Welfare	
 Education and life skills	• Increase enrolment in pre-school, primary and secondary schools • Establish a safe and enabling school environment • Improve children's knowledge about sexual abuse and how to protect themselves against it • Life and social skills training • Adolescent intimate partner violence prevention programmes	Education	

Appendix C – Model National Response

Enablers	Capabilities			Outcomes	
Cross sector, multi-disciplinary collaboration	Policy and Governance 	1	Leadership: An accountable National Governance and Oversight Committee	Highest national commitment to CSEA prevention and response Comprehensive understanding of CSEA within the highest levels of government and law enforcement.	Comprehensive understanding of CSEA within the highest levels of government and law enforcement. Willingness to work with, and co-ordinate the efforts of, multiple stakeholders to ensure the enhanced protection of victims and an enhanced response to CSEA offending.
		2	Research, Analysis and Monitoring: National situational analysis of CSEA risk and response; measurements/indicators		
		3	Legislation: Comprehensive and effective legal framework to investigate offenders and ensure protection for victims		
Willingness to prosecute, functioning justice system and rule of law	Criminal Justice 	4	Dedicated Law Enforcement: National remit, trained officers; proactive and reactive investigations; victim-focused; international cooperation	Effective and successful CSEA investigations, convictions and offender management	Law Enforcement and judiciary have the knowledge, skills, systems and tools required to enable them to perform victim-focused investigations and secure positive judicial outcomes. CSEA offenders are managed and reoffending prevented.
		5	Judiciary and Prosecutors: Trained; victim-focused		
		6	Offender Management Process: Prevent re-offending of those in the criminal justice system nationally and internationally		
		7	Access to Image Databases: National database; link to Interpol database (ICSE)		
Supportive reporting environment	Victim 	8	End to end support: Integrated services provided during investigation, prosecution and after-care	Appropriate support services for children and young people	Children and young people have access to services that support them through the investigation and prosecution of crimes against them. They have access to shelter; specialised medical and psychological services; and rehabilitation, repatriation and resocialization services.
		9	Child Protection Workforce: Trained, coordinated and available to provide victim support		
		10	Compensation, remedies and complaints arrangements: Accessible procedures		
		11	Child Helpline: Victim reporting and support; referrals to services for ongoing assistance		
Aware and supportive public and professionals, working with and for children	Societal 	12	CSEA Hotline: Public and industry reporting for CSEA offences – online and offline; link to law enforcement and child protection systems	CSEA prevented	Children and young people are informed and empowered to protect themselves from CSEA. Parents, carers, teachers and childcare professionals are better prepared to keep children safe from CSEA, including addressing taboos surrounding sexual violence.
		13	Education Programme: For children/young people; parents/carers; teachers; practitioners; faith representatives		
		14	Child Participation: Children and young people have a voice in the development of policy and practice		
		15	Offender Support Systems: Medical, psychological, self-help, awareness.		
Sufficient financial and human resources	Industry 	16	Notice and Takedown Procedures: Local removal and blocking of online CSEA content	Industry engaged in developing solutions to prevent and tackle CSEA	The public can proactively report CSEA offences. Industry has the power and willingness to block and remove online CSEA content and proactively address local CSEA issues.
		17	CSEA Reporting: Statutory protections that would allow industry to fully and effectively report CSEA, including the transmission of content, to law enforcement or another designated agency		
		18	Innovative Solution Development: Industry engagement to help address local CSEA issues		
		19	Corporate Social Responsibility: Effective child-focused programme		

Appendix C – Model National Response ctnd.

Enablers	Capabilities			Outcomes	
National legal and policy frameworks, in accordance with the UNCRC and other international and regional standardsData and evidence on CSEA	 Media and Communications	20	Ethical and informed media reporting: Enable awareness and accurate understanding of problem	Awareness raised among the public, professionals and policy makers	Potential future offenders are deterred. CSEA offending and reoffending is reduced.
		21	Universal terminology: Guidelines and application		

Appendix D – List of existing legislation relevant to Child Online Protection in Zimbabwe

- 1. Censorship and Entertainment Control Act [Chapter 10:04] 1967
- 2. Children’s Act [Chapter 5:06], as amended in 2023
- 3. Constitution of Zimbabwe of 2013
- 4. Criminal Procedure and Evidence Act 1927
- 5. Cyber and Data Protection Act [Chapter 12:07]
- 6. Domestic Violence Act [Chapter 5:16]
- 7. Post and Telecommunications Act [Chapter 12:05] 2000
- 8. The Criminal Law (Codification and Reform) Act [Chapter 9:23] (Act No. 8/2024)
- 9. Trafficking of Persons Act [Chapter 9:25] 2014

Appendix E – Zimbabwe Child Online Protection Committee

- a. Ministry of ICT, Postal and Courier Services
- b. Ministry of Primary and Secondary Education
- c. Ministry of Public Service, Labour and Social Welfare
- d. Ministry of Justice, Legal and Parliamentary Affairs
- e. Zimbabwe Republic Police (Victim Friendly Unit)
- f. POTRAZ
- g. Telecom Operators Association of Zimbabwe
- h. Harare Institute of Technology (Representing Academic Institutions)
- i. UNICEF
- j. Zimbabwe National Council for the Welfare of Children
- k. Childline
- l. Save the Children International
- m. Baker Tilly Digital

